

German unification

After Napoleon's defeat in 1815, many Germans wanted to unite as one nation. A confederation of states was set up, but it was too weak to last. In 1861, Wilhelm I became king of Prussia. Prussia's strength grew, and the other German states agreed to unite with Prussia. At last, in 1871, Wilhelm was made emperor of a united Germany.



Prussian army officer's helmet

Prussian power

A strong army gave Prussia the power to defeat France in the Franco-Prussian War of 1870–71. Prussian strength also enabled the newly-united Germany to negotiate a powerful and advantageous alliance with Austria-Hungary and Russia in 1881. This gave Germany great influence throughout the Continent.

Otto von Bismarck

Otto von Bismarck (1815–98) became chief minister of Prussia in 1862. In a brilliant series of diplomatic and military campaigns he removed all foreign influence from Germany, making Prussia the leading German state. He was chancellor of Germany for 19 years.



Imperial Germany

Under Wilhelm I and Wilhelm II, Germany became the leading power in Europe. Germany sought its 'place in the sun' by acquiring colonies in Africa, China, and the Pacific, but its aggressive foreign policy led to world war in 1914 and the collapse of its empire in 1918.

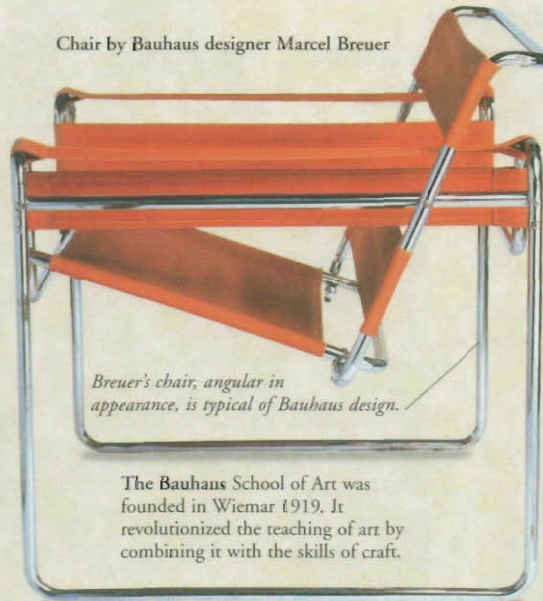


Factories, Ruhr Valley

Industrialization

Between 1870 and 1914, Germany's population rose from 33 to 65 million, and its industrial output quadrupled. The Ruhr Valley became the centre of large iron, coal, steel, and armaments industries. This industrial power helped Germany to become the most powerful state in Europe by 1914, and helped provide resources and finances for World War I.

Chair by Bauhaus designer Marcel Breuer



Breuer's chair, angular in appearance, is typical of Bauhaus design.

The Bauhaus School of Art was founded in Weimar 1919. It revolutionized the teaching of art by combining it with the skills of craft.

Weimar Germany

In 1918, following its defeat in World War I, Germany became a republic. A new constitution was agreed in 1919 in the town of Weimar, where the National Assembly met until it moved back to Berlin in 1920. However, Germany was badly affected by economic problems in the 1920s, and by 1932, over 5 million people were unemployed.



Statuette of soldier



The rise of the Nazis

The unfavourable terms of the peace settlement after World War I, together with the economic failures of the 1930s, saw Germany crippled by high unemployment and hyperinflation, and led to a desire for change among the people. Support grew for the Nazis, an extreme nationalist party led by Adolf Hitler that took power in 1933. The Nazis promised to rebuild Germany's strength and power. It was Hitler's imperialist ambitions that were one of the causes of World War II.

Nazi swastika and eagle badge



Badge of the SS, the Nazi security force



Modern Germany

After World War II, the country was occupied by French, British, US, and Russian troops. In 1949, Germany was divided in two, with a communist, Russian-backed state in the east and US-backed capitalist state in the west.

Living conditions in West Germany were much better than in the east.

Housing complex, East Germany



Reunification

In the late 1980s, Russian control over East Germany weakened. The Berlin Wall, which divided the former capital, was taken down in 1989, and free access between the two countries was guaranteed for the first time. By October 1990, the two halves of Germany were politically united once more.



People flocked to Berlin to see The Wall come down.

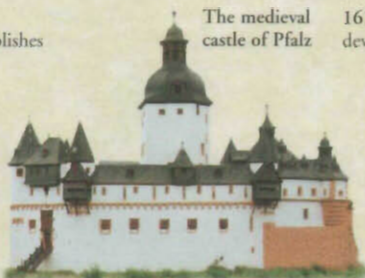
Demolition of the Berlin Wall

Timeline

962 Otto I of Saxony establishes Holy Roman Empire.

1241 Hamburg and Lübeck combine to form Hanseatic League; German trade prospers.

1517 German monk Martin Luther begins Protestant Reformation.



The medieval castle of Pfalz

1618–48 Thirty Years' War devastates Germany.

1740–86 Frederick the Great rules Prussia.

1815–66 German Confederation tries to unite Germany.

1871 Wilhelm I is made German emperor.

1871–90 Bismarck governs as chancellor.

1914–18 Germany fights in World War I, is defeated, and empire collapses.

1919 Weimar Republic is established.

Banknote, 1931

1931 German economy crashes; prices rise, the currency becomes worthless, and many suffer unemployment.



1939–45 Germany fights in World War II.

1949 Germany divided into East and West.

1990 East and West Germany reunited as a single state.

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